ANKYRA

The Gospel, Given to You Straight

From the beginning to the cross, what went wrong, what God has done about it, and what it means for you.

1 In the beginning

'In the beginning' (Genesis 1:1), God gives a brief account of creation within two chapters, concluding that everything He made was 'very good' (Genesis 1:31). Chapter 3 begins with the tempting of Eve by the serpent (Satan), and the fall of mankind that follows. Unlike what most people think, the sin wasn't really about eating a piece of fruit; it was the act of disobeying God's instruction.

Genesis 1–3 · Genesis 2:16–17

2 'You will be like God'

The result of that disobedience was man's fulfilment of the serpent's words, 'you will be like God' (Genesis 3:5), but not in the way Adam and Eve may have thought. In disobeying God, Adam and Eve made themselves their own god. The true consequence of the disobedience was separation from God, who is the source of life: they died spiritually the moment they ate the fruit, and physical death followed in time. This understanding is supported by St Augustine's writings in *The City of God* (Book XIII). And when God says, with heavy irony, 'Behold, the man has become like one of Us, knowing good and evil. And now, lest he reach out his hand and take also from the tree of life, and eat, and live forever…' (Genesis 3:22), and then 'He drove out the man' (Genesis 3:24), it's clear that man very much did not become like God in the sense the serpent's temptation implied.

Genesis 3:5 · Genesis 3:22–24 · Romans 5:12

3 A fallen world

So the rest of the Old Testament, from Genesis 4 through to the beginning of the New Testament (the Gospel of Matthew), gives an account of fallen man in a fallen world, where the vast majority of people do not want a relationship with the God who made them. They want to live for their own temporary pleasures and desires, but to what end? A pitiful one: death. The book of Ecclesiastes addresses this best: existence in vain; a created world in a created universe with created inhabitants, but without reverence for the Creator.

Ecclesiastes 1:2 · Ecclesiastes 12:13–14

4 The promise, from the start

Already in Genesis 3, God promises the outcome: the woman's offspring will crush the serpent's head, while the serpent strikes his heel. That is Jesus against Satan, foretold the moment sin enters the world. Then in Genesis 5, the ten names from Adam to Noah, translated from Hebrew and read in order, spell out a message: Adam (man), Seth (appointed), Enosh (mortal), Kenan (sorrow), Mahalalel (the blessed God), Jared (shall come down), Enoch (teaching), Methuselah (his death shall bring), Lamech (the despairing, or lowly), Noah (rest, or comfort). Not only does God promise a rescuer in Genesis 3; in Genesis 5 He tells us He is coming down Himself.

Genesis 3:15 · Genesis 5 · Genesis 5:29

Three of the meanings are rendered differently by some Hebrew scholars: Kenan as 'possession', Methuselah as 'man of the javelin', and Lamech as uncertain.

5 **Why does Jesus come?**

With the birth of sin in the world through Adam, mankind is trapped in a state of sinfulness. You may yourself be feeling the weight of the wrong in your life right now, and the helpless feeling of being unable to change. Jesus speaks to this exact situation: 'everyone who sins is a slave to sin' (John 8:34). Without Jesus we are in a state of depravity and corruption; our nature is no longer perfect, as God had made it in Genesis.

But this leaves two problems. Firstly, God is just, and the penalty for sin is death (Romans 6:23). Secondly, all have sinned and fall short (Romans 3:23). Mankind needs redeeming to enter God's presence again, but can't, because all have sinned. So, because God is just, there must be payment for the wrongdoing, and because all have sinned, we cannot atone for it (pay for it) ourselves. Mankind is in a state of hopelessness.

John 8:34 · Romans 6:23 · Romans 3:23

This is where the beauty of the gospel (the good news) lies. God is not a distant God, ignorant of our situation, but a present God who enters in. Jesus, who is fully God, takes on a human nature and unites it to His divine one. He lived a sinless life; He lived perfectly, teaching us how we should live. At the end of His life, on the cross, He atones for all who put their faith in Him. Having lived perfectly in the way we never could, innocent yet sacrificed, His innocent blood pays for us.

So, Jesus offered Himself for you! Why? Because He loves you, and so that all mankind through Him can be restored to God and gain access to His presence once more: the very reversal of sin entering through Adam.

Romans 5:8 · Romans 5:12–19

Jesus' sacrifice satisfies the blood atonement that was required (Hebrews 9:22), and so the good news is this:

- **God has come and done what you could not do.**
- **God, in His grace, offers you a way out of the hopelessness you may be feeling.** If you place your faith in His Son Jesus and sincerely repent (with heartfelt sorrow, say sorry to God and turn away from what is wrong), then when Jesus returns, you will be saved. Here's the catch: this faith is an active, ongoing faith. It's not an empty declaration of faith before we go on living sinfully with no remorse, but a genuine belief and trust in God and His promise of salvation. Hebrews 10:22–26
- **God loves you** (John 3:16), **wants a relationship with you** (1 John 1:3), **and invites you to be His child** (John 1:12).
- **Jesus is alive now.** He rose on the third day, and He is seated at the right hand of the Father in heaven. Jesus reigns now; He is in control of everything. 1 Corinthians 15:4 · Hebrews 1:3 · Matthew 28:18

If your heart has changed

RECOGNISE THIS

If reading this has prompted your heart to change, recognise this: if you truly repent and put your faith in Jesus and abide in Him, you are forgiven, completely. You are adopted into God's family. You are empowered by God's Spirit dwelling in you (the Holy Spirit, the third person of the triune God, whom you can talk to right now) to change you from the inside, so that you might live more like Jesus. John 15:4 · Romans 8:1 · Romans 8:15–16

KNOW THIS

Life does not become easy. In fact, it will remain hard or become even harder: you're now in a struggle, for the rest of your life, to be more like Jesus. But your life has now truly begun, because God has made you spiritually alive, and God is now with you every step of the way in the journey ahead.

Where to go from here

WHETHER YOU HAVE JUST TURNED TO JESUS OR ARE STILL WEIGHING IT UP

The gospel is not an idea to agree with and put on a shelf. It makes a claim on the whole of your life. So if you are not sure, it deserves to be tested properly; and if it is true, it deserves to be followed.

If you are not sure yet

TEST IT, DO NOT TAKE IT ON TRUST

1 **Read one Gospel, start to finish**

Matthew, Mark, Luke and John are the accounts of Jesus' life, written 'so that you may believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God'. Mark can be read in an evening. Make up your mind about Jesus from what He actually said and did, not from what you have heard about Him.

John 20:31

2 **Look hard at the resurrection**

Everything rests on it. Paul says plainly that if Christ has not been raised, faith is worthless and you are still in your sins. So push hardest there. On ankyra.uk, the notes on Matthew 28 and 1 Corinthians 15 set out the earliest evidence.

1 Corinthians 15:3–8 · 1 Corinthians 15:14–17

3 **Bring your hardest questions**

Suffering, hell, the violence in the Old Testament, whether Adam was a real man. *Questions people ask* on ankyra.uk answers 25 of the hardest honestly, each linked to the passage it comes from, and says where Christians disagree.

4 **Ask God**

If He is there, He can hear you. 'God, if you are real, show me' is an honest prayer, and He has promised that those who seek Him with all their heart will find Him.

Jeremiah 29:13

If you have turned to Him

THE FIRST STEPS

1 **Talk to God every day**

Prayer is not a performance and there are no special words. Tell Him what you have done, that you are sorry, and that you are trusting Jesus. Then keep talking to Him. *How to Pray* will help.

2 **Read the Bible, a little every day**

Little and often beats a lot and rarely. Start with Matthew, which has the fullest notes on ankyra.uk, or follow the six-week plan through Mark in *Reading the Bible on Your Own*.

3 **Find a church**

You were never meant to do this alone. Look for one where the Bible is opened and explained and the cross is central; *Finding a church* on ankyra.uk sets out what to look for. If you have not been baptised, ask about it there: Jesus commands it, though Christians differ on who should be baptised, and how.

Hebrews 10:24–25 · Matthew 28:19 · Acts 2:38

4 **When you fall, come straight back**

You will still sin. Do not hide it and do not wait until you feel better. Confess it to God straight away: 'He is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness.'

1 John 1:9 · Philippians 1:6

WHY ANKYRA

'We have this hope as an anchor for the soul, firm and secure.' *Ankyra* is Greek for 'anchor'. The hope set out here is not a feeling that comes and goes. It is a person, Jesus, who holds you when nothing else does.

Hebrews 6:19

On ankyra.uk you will find the whole Bible with study notes, *Questions people ask*, Apologetics, Finding a church, and the guides *How to Pray*, *Reading the Bible on Your Own*, *Church Words Explained* and *The Bible Story in Ten Steps*, all free.

© Ankyra. Free to print and share for non-commercial use (Creative Commons BY-NC 4.0). The whole Bible, with study notes: ankyra.uk